Module 2 - Slide Deck Video Transcription

1 Hi, I'm Jordan Reyes from Tallgrass Advisory. Quick reminder: I'm a fictional character presented by an AI avatar. That's on purpose, because this course is about using AI well and being open about it. Last week you learned what AI can do. This week you learn how to ask. Walt Brenner, Velox's Controller, wants to know whether AI can write his team's monthly variance summary, and he honestly isn't sure it can be trusted. Your job is to show him a method he can trust.

2 Here's Walt's problem. Every month his team writes a one-page variance summary for the executives. A variance is the gap between what the budget said would happen and what actually happened. It takes about three hours, and executives act on it, so it has to be right. Walt has seen AI make things up. He isn't against it. He wants proof. Notice what he's really asking for: not magic, but a method his team can repeat and check.

3 Remember the first thing you did this week: you asked AI for the summary in your own words. If the answer felt generic, that isn't because AI is bad. AI can't see your situation. When you leave details out, it guesses the average case. The fix is context. Every technique I'm about to teach is a way of giving AI the right context, and I'll name each one so you can recognize it anywhere.

4 First technique: the five-part request. Practitioners call this structured prompting, and the role part is called role prompting. You tell AI the role, the goal, the audience, the format, and the constraints. Why it helps: each part answers a question AI would otherwise guess, so your first draft lands closer to what you need. And when you ask for a specific shape, like a headline and three bullets, that's called structured output. It makes the answer easy to scan and easy to check.

5 Second technique: grounding. That means giving AI the facts and telling it to use only those facts. A sentence like: use only the data below, and if the data doesn't say why something happened, write not in the data. Why it helps: AI answers from your facts instead of from memory, which cuts invented numbers and invented reasons. And every claim becomes checkable, because you know which source it should come from.

6 Third technique: few-shot prompting. You show AI one or a few examples of what good looks like. For Walt, that's last quarter's summary. Why it helps: an example teaches tone, length, and layout faster than any list of rules. One warning: tell AI to match the style, but to use only this quarter's numbers. Otherwise it can copy the example's facts by mistake.

7 Fourth technique: clarifying questions. You add one line asking AI to ask you up to three questions before it writes, and to wait for your answers. Why it helps: AI finds the gaps in your request before it writes, so you fix them once, not after a full draft. You're still in charge. You decide how to answer, and you can say, that doesn't matter.

8 Let me put it together. Here's my request for Walt's summary. The role: a financial analyst on the Controller's team. The goal: the one-page Q3 results versus budget summary. The audience: executives who read for two minutes. The format: a one-sentence headline, three bullets, and a watch list. The constraints: dollars in thousands, and label each variance favorable or unfavorable. Then the grounding sentence, the example, and the line asking Claude to question me first. I attached two files: Walt's Q3 report, with the internal notes column taken out for now, and last quarter's summary as my example. More on those notes in a minute. Notice it's all plain English. No magic words. Just clear answers to the questions AI would otherwise guess.

9 I sent that to Claude, and it didn't write anything yet. It asked me three questions first, exactly as I requested. One: the file gives no reasons for any variance, so should it write not in the data for causes? Yes, that's what I want. Two: it proposed three bullets, revenue and cost of goods sold, the severance accrual, and the smaller lines, and asked whether to mention the lines that were on budget. That grouping works, and yes, mention them. Three: who should be named as preparer? I told it to leave a placeholder, because a person will put their name there. Notice what happened. Claude found the gaps in my request before it wrote, so I fixed them once, instead of after a full draft.

10 Here is what Claude wrote. This is the real output from my run, shortened to fit the slide. The headline says operating income finished 16,600 thousand dollars below budget, driven by lower revenue, higher cost of goods sold, and an unbudgeted severance accrual of 3,100 thousand. Each bullet gives the numbers and labels every variance favorable or unfavorable. And look at the causes. Where the file doesn't say why, Claude wrote not in the data. That's the grounding sentence doing its job. It's fast and it's well organized, but I'm not done. I'm the one who's accountable for these numbers, so now I check.

11 Here's the part Walt cares about: checking. I pick three claims from Claude's summary and check each one against the file. One: operating income finished 16,600 below budget. In the file, budget is 59,400 and actual is 42,800, in thousands. The difference is 16,600. That matches. Two: without the severance accrual, operating expenses would have been 42,100, which is 500 favorable. Claude calculated that itself, so I redo it. Actual operating expenses are 45,200. Take away the 3,100 accrual and you get 42,100. The budget was 42,600, so that's 500 under. That matches too. Three: Claude says the cause of the revenue shortfall is not in the data. Is there a reason anywhere in the file? No. So Claude was right to

say so, and the next step is a person's job: ask Cost and Planning. Without a line like my grounding sentence, AI is more likely to fill a gap like that with a reason that sounds right. Three checks, a few minutes, and Walt can see exactly how.

12 One more thing, and it matters as much as any technique: confidentiality. The more context you give AI, the better the answer. But context can include things that should never leave Velox. Walt's file has internal notes: a supplier's name and contract price, a planned price increase dealers haven't heard about, a legal settlement estimate, a bonus for a named role, and a restructuring plan for employees who haven't been told. For each note you'll decide: keep it, generalize it, or remove it. Generalize means replace the specifics with general words, like a carbon-fiber supplier. Ask two questions: does the summary need it, and would it cause harm if it leaked? Give AI what it needs, and nothing more.

13 Here's your week. You'll try Walt's task in your own words before I teach you anything. Then you'll learn the techniques, decide what stays out, and run it again the structured way. You'll check three claims, compare your two attempts, and turn your best prompt into a reusable template, the Prompt Playbook, with a short note to Walt. Write your own prompts. I'm not handing you magic words. Let's get to work.